Counter-Mapping Diaspora and Crime: A Digital Study of Colombian Spatialities in New York and London

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This short paper aims to report progress on a project that explores the transformative potential of digital mapping to offer a nuanced representation of diasporic identities. The research focuses on Colombian communities in New York and London and interrogates the affordances of digital mapping to democratize processes of epistemology that have long been confined to mainstream media and state agents. Hegemonic representations of the drug trade have essentialized the Colombian community around the world to a criminalized "other." This stigmatizing shadow is particularly palpable in the United States, where media sources have generalized Colombian ethnic neighborhoods such as Jackson Heights, New York, as havens for crime since the 1980s. Although these representations bear some reflection of reality, they distort the place of diasporic contributions in the historical record. This study examines this dynamic by layering hegemonic representations of Colombian presence in New York and London along with counter-hegemonic, migrant-built discursive spheres on a digital map. The superposition of these two perspectives aims to provide a fuller picture of Colombian diasporas that does not ignore the ways migrants have historically negotiated with the drug trade but does not either make this the centerpiece of their identity. In contribution to the goals of the conference, this study issues a set of recommendations to guide future digital mapping work that promotes community-minded processes of history-making.

Historical Background

As historians have demonstrated, discourses of drug-related criminalization have been regenerated for various ethnic and racial categories throughout the past century, creating a pattern of foreign "blame" for the drug trade (Lassiter 2015; Clark Kinder 1991). These hegemonic definitions had palpable consequences for the identity-making strategies of the diaspora. Most notably, the presence of the drug trade has led to "increased levels of social fragmentation and generalized mistrust" (Guarnizo et al. 1999: 373).

In response to stigmatization, Colombians have attempted to put forward alternative definitions of their identity. For some, this has signified separating the "bad Colombians" from the "good Colombians" by reinforcing pre-existing power relations such as those of social class, race, and documentation status (Ochoa Camacho 2016; Rincón et al. 2020). Here, we encounter a conundrum: while hegemonic representations of Colombians advance a criminalized image, some counter-narratives only serve to further fragment the community. While both perspectives bear some truth of the lived experience of the Colombian diaspora, to offer one without the other is to conform to the very structures that have made essentialization possible.

Methodology and Rationale

How can a digital map address this conundrum? Aren't maps, after all, just another incomplete representation of an experience, one more way in which we conceive of a space that is lived in?

Scholars of digital and spatial humanities have proposed the concept of "deep mapping," where the tools of humanistic and geographical inquiry are put in service of the study of occupied space as memory, imagination, and experience (Bodenhamer 2016). As Stuart Dunn (2022) recognizes, "to map" involves ontologizing—the breakdown of a complex reality into discrete components for human understanding (206). Although digital mapping, through its quantitative basis, ontologizes and defines place in a "particularly aggressive" way, it also bears the ability to generate new meanings.

We may understand this ability by contemplating that hegemonic discourses essentialize a certain subject and generalize this narrative across an extended space. Digital human geography bears the capabilities to act against both impulses. The digital age has brought a renewed interest in the navigational purpose of maps, instead of their mimetic use (November et al. 2010). In other words, as maps move from static to mobile, it becomes possible to depict features in constant transformation (Deleuze / Guattari 2007: 12). Furthermore, a digital map's expandable and specific features allow for place-based redefinitions of a space, an "anti-essentialized notion of place, (...)

place being constructed, imagined, and struggled over" (Escobar 2001: 143). A static map may generalize, but a map that users can engage with reinfuses the representation with specificity.

So far, several scholars have made spatial interventions into the field of the Colombian diaspora. Román-Velázquez and Retis (2020) conducted a study to map Latin American "discursive spheres" in London. This idea of the "discursive sphere," defined as "where members of minority groups create and circulate counter-discourses" is crucial for this study (108). In terms of methodology, this project "reverse engineers" a data from primary and secondary sources to create a digital map (Whitworth / Ayers 2022). Challenges such as archival injustice make it labor-intensive to source counter-narratives from the counter-definers themselves. However, it is possible to "mine" hegemonic sources for names, locations, and stories of the community that push the bounds of the definer's narrative. In this case, the data was acquired from New York Times and The Times articles dated between 1979-2010, which constitute the decades of highest emigration for Colombians (Guarnizo 2008). Then, selected sources were geocoded for geographical data. The result is a digital map that superimposes both the hegemonic and the "mined" narratives and captures features in a non-hierarchical manner.

Key Findings and Contribution to Conference

This project was driven forward by two case studies. The first zooms in on a series of death-related incidents that took place in the Colombian community in Jackson Heights between the 1980s-2000s and examines the negotiations between migrant livelihood and the violence of the drug trade (Figure 1). The second focuses on the invisibility of Colombians in the British newspaper archive, and how a BBC documentary about ethnic music in London offers a rare perspective into the Colombian diaspora (Figure 2). The case of New York particularly challenged the digital map to recontextualize place-based migrant practices, whose heterogeneities are not immediately apparent in the newspaper archive. By contrast, the London case, where the Colombian diaspora is less spatially condensed, challenged the digital map to depict practices that move between the local and the transnational and are subject to travelling imaginaries of Colombian criminality. These case studies culminate in a reflection on the importance of the map's navigational and interactive qualities, including the presence of pop-up metadata. Furthermore, it encourages a move away from an indexical form of archiving, towards an "expanded" view that incorporates the moment of spectatorship as part of the process of history-making. By utilizing digital mapping to make visible previously obscured or essentialized histories, this project aligns closely with the conference theme, which promotes open access and the democratization of knowledge.

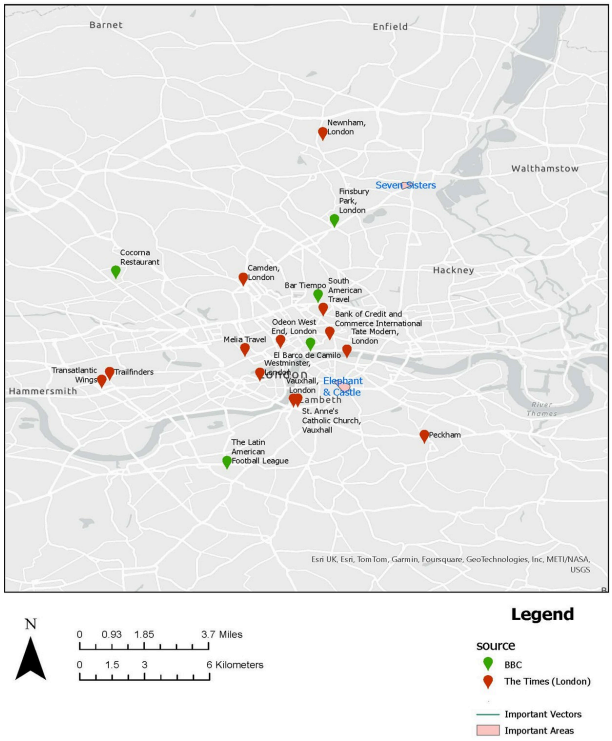

Figure 1. Map of Colombian Spatialities in New York City.

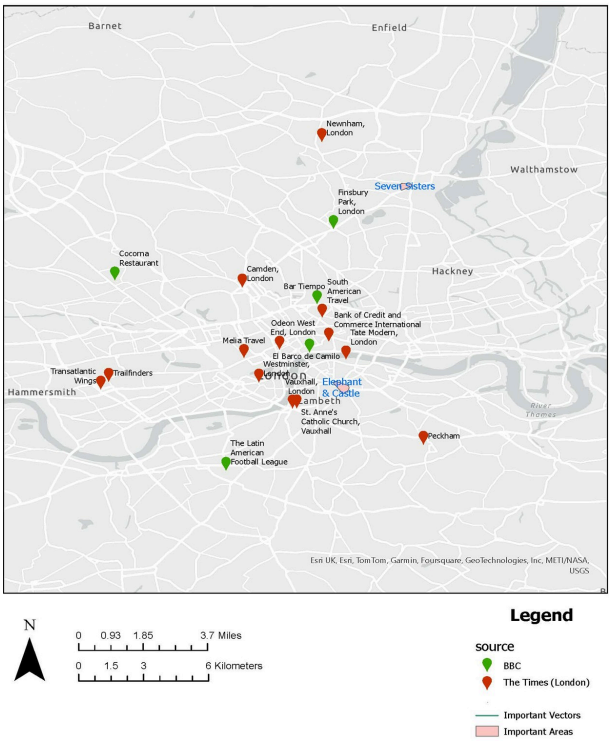

Figure 2. Map of Colombian spatialities in London.

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